Wednesday, 18 March 2026 (29 Adar 5786) — Preparing and Leading the פסח Seder (Guest Shiur, Rabbi Yechiel Spero)

Independent review · read fresh, from the finished HTML only (as delivered, before part-3 corrections) · 8 November 2026

1.Overall Read

A nineteen-section write-up (roughly 4,300 words of body plus a fourteen-note *Mareh Mekomos* apparatus of about 1,200 words) of a guest talk on preparing and leading the *Pesach seder*. It is lively, practical and well organized in the first two-thirds: the goal, the child-involvement toolkit, the reward arithmetic and the question-driven *seder* are clear, and the close returns to the opening idea. The hard editorial issues are six: (a) the voice is the speaker's first person throughout while the footnotes speak of "Rabbi Spero" in the third person, and the header calls the piece "reworked"; (b) the props are scattered across five sections (VII, X–XII, XV) with repetition; (c) several passages assume knowledge the reader does not have ("multiply by two," the "list of שיעורים," Seasons Express, Amir); (d) the Hebrew-inline convention is inconsistent (bare Hebrew in running text, mixed-script headings, transliteration absent); (e) the apparatus contains working notes, an internal file cross-reference and figures that disagree with the body; and (f) there is no Hebrew date and no statement of where or when the talk was given beyond a civil date.

2.What Works

- **The opening (I).** Taking the everyday הכל בסדר and finding in it a claim about the whole year is a strong, memorable start, and the line written on the first page of the personal *haggadah* (“relax… not your performance”) sets the tone of the whole piece.
  - **The Hidden Mathematics (VII).** The arithmetic ($25; 100, 50 or 200 shekalim) is stated in four sentences and a reader can reproduce it. It is the best-engineered passage in the document.
  - **Two Bowls (XI) and the mannequin challenge (XII).** Each is a concrete device with a clear mechanism and a clear point (the children listening for slavery and freedom; the frozen elders and the searching children).
- **The מבית עבדים argument (XVII).** The question (why the redundancy, seven weeks after the exodus), the answer (paint the picture to renew the feeling) and the application (talk about the miracles, not clever *divrei Torah*) form a real piece of Torah in three short subsections and give the practical advice a theory.
- **The summary (סיכום).** It restates the central idea (the child’s כח to ask, the parent’s to answer) and closes the arc.
  - **Footnote hygiene.** Fourteen notes in body order with matching back-links; the Hebrew-inline convention is used in the apparatus consistently.

3.Where It’s Weak or Could Be Sharper

Voice. The body is the speaker’s own (“I prepare my [illegible] with great care,” “I have no filter, unfortunately,” “my father [illegible] the header says “Reworked from the original [illegible] the footnotes say “Rabbi Spero’s reward system” and “the [illegible] reenactment,” and the colophon says the

text was “reworked from a guest שיעור”. For a book the voice needs to be chosen: either a speaker-labelled third person (“the lecturer”) or a first-person talk with a clear note of provenance. Quips that read as asides in speech (“I have no filter, unfortunately”; “I tell them not to go”) do different work in print.

The props are scattered. Props appear in XI (house), XII (plagues), XIV (reenactment), XV (pictures) and XVIII (the item exercise), separated by non-prop sections (XIII, XVI, XVII); the plagues are treated as props in XII and again as pictures in XV, and the house displays appear in XI and in XV. Grouping “before פסח” at the שולחן and “the מכות” would remove the repetition and shorten the book.

Section II, sticky notes. “Today, sadly, children come home from school and forget the והגדת לבנך : מצוה” is a non sequitur as written (children forgetting a מצוה is not what the paragraph then explains); it reads as if a clause is missing. The reader also has to infer, from the next paragraph, what the five sticky notes are for.

Section VI, the bags. “Count the people at your seder, multiply by two” (two of what?), “the שעורים of מצה for each part” (no figures given, and fn 4 supplies figures the text does not use), and “Because מצה is not like slicing חלה” (unexplained) leave the practical instruction unusable. The parenthesis on the objection that the measuring is part of the experience is hard to follow.

Unexplained particulars. “Seasons Express,” “my older son Amir,” “Party City,” “Mega Button candies” and the dollar figures are all given without any note for a reader outside the speaker’s world or in ten years. A short gloss, or removal of brand names, would help.

Section VII and the forward reference. Section III promises “we will return to them” for the Seder Shekalim; the return comes four sections later with a repeated explanation. One mention would do.

The ending of XVIII. “One year, this exercise convinced a mother who had insisted on leaving the seder at 10:00 PM… she brought a picture of her boss and declared her freedom” is told with no context (whose mother, why a picture of a

boss), and the example “a picture of a boss after thirty years of employment: slavery transformed into freedom” a few lines earlier already covers the same ground.

Safety and sensitivity. Section XIV recommends laying the youngest child across “bricks” with “more cushions placed on top.” Section XI lists a knife prop, XIX tells of a poster of an inappropriately dressed woman. Each is the speaker’s own story, but a printed edition would need a sentence of caution on the first, and the second would be better told without the detail.

Section XII: the frog. The line about hiding it “for ten and a half months” after buying it at חנוכה is a joke that works in speech; in print the arithmetic does not hold (Chanukah to Pesach is a few months), and the line needs correcting or removal.

Headings. Section titles mix scripts (“I. הכל בסדר A Deeper Meaning,” “VI. Pre-Measured Bags of מצה and מרור,” IX. התרוממות Through Relaxation”) and differ in form (questions, noun phrases, imperatives). They should be parallel.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Fn 1. The note cites the Chida’s *Rosh Kol Pesach* and, with “cf.,” *Simchas HaRegel* without a locator, then states a “kabbalistic underpinning” for which no source is given. Rosh Hashanah 2a is cited in a way that implies the Mishnah states that the *seder* “draws down the spiritual flow”; it does not. A reader cannot tell which part is the speaker’s.

Fn 2. “see file 58 fn 10 for the four occurrences in the ה” is a reference to another document in a series and is meaningless to a reader. Also, the note cites ח:ז ת"ג while the body’s paraphrase (“*you* shall tell *your son*”) is of the verb and not the verse; the note does not say why this verse and not the others.

Fn 3 and fn 6 overlap. Both cite Mishnah Pesachim 10:5 and the Rambam 7:6 with the same two quotations; fn 3 says the Chida “and others read” the

Rambam's variant as an obligation to physically demonstrate, and fn 6 says the Rambam "reads it more strongly." They should be one note, and the Chida claim needs a source or removal.

Fn 4 and fn 10 disagree with the body and with each other. The body gives wine as "approximately 3.3 ounces." Fn 4 gives *rov revi'is* as ~75 ml / ~2.5 oz per cup with 90–98 ml / ~3.3 oz as the stricter view; fn 10 says "most קים" hold *rov revi'is* and that modern measures range from 75 to 98 ml. The note then lists ז at "approximately 30 g (one half of a hand-shmurah)" for each of three items, with no source and an unexplained unit. The closing "Verify against contemporary halachic guides" is a working note and should not appear in print.

Fn 5. It quotes שישאלו at Pesachim 116a and lists the irregularities of the *seder* ("dipping twice, leaning, the second cup, the breaking of the matzah"). The list mixes things the Gemara ties to the children's questions with things it does not, and the exact phrase should be checked against the page.

Fn 7. The note says *Chazal* (Shabbos 97a) "develop the theological significance" that the staff, after returning to its original form, still contained the swallowed staffs. The statement is specific, unsourced in the text, and should be checked.

Fn 8. "*Midrash Shemos Rabbah* 22:1" and "*Tanna DeVei Eliyahu* on פרשת ות" are both questionable locators for the Egyptians' use of Jewish children as bricks: a passage about the taskmasters of Exodus 1 would be expected in the first chapters of *Shemos Rabbah*, and *Tanna DeVei Eliyahu* is not arranged by *parashah*. The note's claim that the *midrash* is "widely cited in pre-פס ז educational materials" is not a citation.

Fn 9. "Draws on the kabbalistic principle that *Shiras HaYam* at the *seder* reactivates the original moment of redemption" has no source.

Fn 11 and fn 12. Fn 11 says "many ־שים" read the phrase as a model for painting a picture, with only the *Shefa Chaim* named. Fn 12 gives R' Chaim Friedlander's dates (1923–1986) and describes the book as a "multi-volume

collection” of his talks. The title as given (ת חיים) should be compared with the title of his published series, and the claim that this idea “is widely cited” needs a source.

Fn 13. It places המרבה לספר “immediately following the four sons” and calls the story of the sages of Bnei Brak a *midrash*. In the standard text the line comes in the paragraph before the Bnei Brak story, and the story is part of the *haggadah*. The note should say that.

Fn 14. “Amazon-affiliate,” “updated annually” and “free access” are statements about a website that a print edition cannot stand behind without a source; the note also reads as an advertisement.

In the body. “A full moon (which always appears on the fifteenth of)” is a loose statement of the usual rule; “210 years” is the traditional figure for the stay in ־ים and should be marked so; the pineapple and tin-pan prop (XII) names a 9 x 13 pan without saying it is a baking pan; and the claim that the ־ש “teaches that the ז of penetrated not only the water but the bodies and fruits” has no locator at all.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- The convention for Hebrew is inconsistent: מצה ,פסח ,ליל הסדר and סדר appear bare in running text, sometimes in italic, with “seder” and “seder shekel” in English beside them. Choose transliteration with Hebrew in parentheses on first use, or Hebrew only inside `heb-inline` spans, and apply it throughout.
  - The header says “Recorded 18 March 2026” and carries no Hebrew date; the other editions give both. The lead calls the shiur “mid-week,” which is not a claim a reader can check.
- Capitalization and form vary: “Seder Shekel” / “Seder Shekalim,” “*chol hamoed*” (un-Hebrew) / חול המועד, “yid” / “yidden,” “שיעורים“ / ”שיעור” used both for the talk and for the halachic measures.

- The footnote form is mixed: most notes are “short + expanded,” fn 4 and fn 14 are “short + Note.” Use one.
- Section XVI, “Wine,” and the sentence on cup size are the only halachic content in a long practical section and read as an aside; consider moving them next to the bags.

- The summary section (סיכום) is the only unnumbered section and is not in the same form as the others.
- The lead promises a talk “pointed toward a single goal.” An added sentence at the end of XIX (“Seder Shekalim, signs and props all serve one thing”) would let the reader see the synthesis.

6.Bottom Line

> *A readable, practical write-up with a strong core (the goal, the shekalim, the questions, עבדים). It needs one mechanical pass (voice, the Hebrew-inline convention, the Hebrew date), one regrouping of the props into three sections, one clean-up of the apparatus (remove the file cross-reference and the working note, reconcile the cup and i figures, merge fn 3 and fn 6, and hedge or source fn 1, 5, 7, 8, 9, 12, 13 and 14), and a few glosses for a reader outside the speaker’s world. With those done it can stand as a sefer chapter.*

Produced by an independent editorial pass reading the finished HTML only, without the transcript. Reviewer brings the perspective of a learned general reader familiar with the Haggadah, Mishnah Pesachim chapter 10 and the Rambam’s *Mishneh Torah*.